

4 UNIVERSITY OF CALCUTTA Old World Charm

With an increased focus on research, the tradition of academic brilliance continues in one of the oldest modern universities

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The name of Calcutta was changed to Kolkata, a few years back, but the name of the famed University of Calcutta (or CU as its students often call it), established in 1857, remains the same. Set up during the British rule, the university is considered to be one of the oldest of the modern universities in the world. The days of the Raj are still rekindled every time a tram trundles along near the university campus. Every year more than 80,000 students secure admission in 153 under-graduate colleges of CU and about 12,000 students at the post-graduation level. "We have been able to strike a fine balance between what is known as conventional subjects like humanity, literature, social science, fine arts and emerging areas like biotechnology, biochemistry, molecular biology and nanotechnology," says Professor Suranjan Das, vice-chancellor, CU. "In 2007, the Government of India gave us a grant of Rs 100 crore to set up a centre for nanotechnology. We are developing it into a centre for excellence," says Das. CU also boasts of having churned the most number of Nobel laureates in India with Ronald Ross, Rabindranath Tagore, C.V. Raman and Amartya Sen all associated with it. With first two graduates being greats like Bankim Chandra Chatterjee and Juddonath Bose, students have great examples to follow.

Despite an enviable record, CU falls short in the teacher-student ratio that currently stands at 1: 22. "We are not that fortunate to have a great ratio like central universities. But if you look at

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the input and output ratio, the situation is much better here," says Das.

In 2005, CU was recognised by the UGC as a university with Potential for Excellence. And the tradition of excellence continues with an increased focus on research. In 2008, it established two new research centres, the UGC-supported Rabindranath Tagore Centre for

Human Development with the Institute of Development Studies, Kolkata, and the Ministry of External Affairs and the Government of India-sponsored Institute of Foreign Policy Studies.

Since 2009, CU started offering a post-graduate diploma course in sports science, a post-graduate course in Buddhist studies, undergraduate general course in women's studies and biochemistry, a composite undergraduate course in fashion and apparel design. The university now offers a B.Ed course with a Method Paper in Home Science. "We aim to improve CU's standing through more international collaborations, faculty and student exchanges," says Professor Basab Chaudhuri, registrar of the university.

by Sarbani Sen



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SURANJAN DAS, vice-chancellor, University of Calcutta